

Effortless Mindfulness: Loch Kelly's Approach to Awake Awareness

Overview of Loch Kelly's Effortless Mindfulness

Loch Kelly is a psychotherapist and meditation teacher known for synthesizing Tibetan Buddhist wisdom (Mahamudra/Dzogchen lineages) with modern psychology ¹. His method, often called **"Effortless Mindfulness,"** is a direct approach to awakening that does not require lengthy, rigid meditation sessions. The core thesis is that the **"awake awareness"** we seek is not something we have to create – it is an ever-present natural state already built into us. Our task is simply to uncover or **"unhook"** from our habitual small self (the thinking mind) to access this innate awareness ² ³. In Loch's words, *"the awake heart-mind that we are seeking is already here within us, as our true nature"* ².

Instead of forcefully concentrating or trying to suppress thoughts, Effortless Mindfulness uses brief shifts in awareness to reveal the quiet clarity that's **already present** beyond the chattering mind ² ⁴. Kelly's approach is influenced by Tibetan "pointing out" instructions, which quickly point you back to the awareness that is **already awake**. Below are some key principles of this approach:

- **Awake Awareness is Already Present:** The *"awake, aware mind"* you seek is **already within you** at all times – it is your true nature or natural awareness ². Enlightenment is not something to attain in the future, but to recognize here and now by removing the mental noise that obscures it.
- **Suffering = Mistaken Identity:** According to this view, we suffer because of a case of mistaken identity – awareness identifies with the **small self** (the stream of thoughts, ego, worry) and feels isolated or lacking ⁵ ⁶. By realizing we are actually the open awareness *behind* our thoughts (not the thoughts themselves), this feeling of lack and struggle can dissolve.
- **Micro-Meditations ("Glimpses"):** Rather than long, strenuous meditation, Loch Kelly teaches *"micro-meditations"* called **glimpses**. These are very short practices (as quick as 10 seconds) that *shift your awareness* out of the thinking mind and into awake awareness ⁷ ⁴. Each glimpse is like a small **"reset"** where you directly taste the natural calm and clarity of your true nature.
- **Shift Instead of Strive:** Effortless Mindfulness is about **shifting the location of your knowing** instead of trying to force the mind to be quiet. In practice, this might mean simply moving your awareness out of your head and into the space around you, rather than narrowing down on thoughts. For example, Kelly suggests you can *"let awareness move to the corner of the room and look back"* at yourself – a quick shift that immediately opens up a new perspective ⁸. By relocating awareness in this way, the mind often *naturally* calms and thoughts become background noise without any suppression.

In summary, Loch Kelly's approach is "effortless" because you **don't fight or control** your mind's content; instead, you **surrender into the awareness that is already awake** ⁹. With practice, this awake awareness (also called open-hearted awareness) becomes your default state, leading to a sense of ease, clarity, compassion, and connection in daily life.

What Are “Glimpses” in Effortless Mindfulness?

Kelly’s main teaching tool is the **mindful glimpse** – a tiny meditation or insight moment designed to reveal awake awareness directly. A glimpse is essentially a brief **shift of consciousness**. Loch Kelly describes it as a kind of “*shifting, letting go, dropping, or stopping*” that allows a natural clarity and connectedness to emerge ¹⁰. In other words, you momentarily **stop identifying with the busy mind** and let awareness reveal itself. These glimpses are like mini “*rest stops*” for your mind, in which you “*refresh or reboot*” your whole body-mind system ¹⁰.

Importantly, a glimpse is **not** an analytic insight or thought – it’s a **direct experience** of the peaceful, wise awareness that has “*always been here*” inside you ¹⁰. Many spiritual traditions refer to such immediate awakenings: in Tibetan Buddhism, a sudden recognition of awareness is called “*flashing on the awakened heart-mind*.” Similarly, Loch notes that a glimpse is akin to a Zen koan in that it yanks you out of conceptual thinking – “*awareness unhooking from thought*” – except a glimpse doesn’t require pondering a riddle; it simply starts by shifting awareness itself ¹¹.

How do glimpses work? Essentially, they involve **redirecting or releasing your focus** in a subtle way: - Sometimes a glimpse is initiated by a *sensory shift* (for example, stopping what you’re doing to listen to sounds, then listening to the silence or space around sounds). - Other times it’s a *perspective shift* (for example, moving the “camera” of your mind from first-person view to a third-person or all-directions view, as in the corner-of-the-room exercise).

- It can also be a *self-inquiry* prompt that makes you look for the awareness or the “you” who is aware, until you directly experience a different sense of self (more spacious and not located in the head).

Glimpses are very **short** and meant to be done **anytime, anywhere** – even eyes open, in the middle of your normal day. In Loch’s books, he offers many such micro-exercises that can take “*from ten seconds to ten minutes*” each ¹². The idea is to weave them into daily life. Each glimpse “*shifts you into a new operating system*” of mind – from the small-self mode into what Kelly calls open, awake awareness mode ¹². Rather than one long meditation session, the **primary practice is “small glimpses, many times”** ¹² throughout the day. Over time, these repeated small shifts help you familiarize with awake awareness until it stabilizes. As Loch Kelly quips, it’s like short frequent visits to your *home* in awareness, so eventually you live from there full-time.

Students often find these micro-meditations extremely effective. Even a **single glimpse** can sometimes feel as powerful as an entire retreat: “*several of my students have told me that dropping into one small glimpse has been as life changing as going on a long meditation retreat*” ¹³. Of course, every individual is different – if one particular glimpse technique doesn’t click for you, you simply try another ¹³. There are many doorways to the same awakened awareness. The key is to experiment and find the pointers that help **unhook your awareness** most easily.

How to Practice Effortless Mindfulness (Step-by-Step Glimpses)

Effortless Mindfulness is practiced through simple “glimpse” exercises that you can do in the midst of everyday life. Instead of sitting for an hour hoping your mind quiets, you can take **10-60 seconds “micro-**

meditation” breaks where you intentionally shift into awake awareness. Below are two **basic glimpse practices** from Loch Kelly’s teachings that you can try right now:

• **Glimpse 1: “Wordless Awareness”** – *This exercise uses a sensory shift to help you drop out of the thinking mind:*

1. **Redirect your focus to sound:** Allow your awareness to move from whatever you were just doing (e.g. reading or thinking) to **hearing the sounds** around you. Simply listen, letting sounds come and go.
2. **Notice the open space around you:** Now gently shift from hearing *objects* (sounds) to noticing the **silence or space** in which sounds occur. Become interested in the open, objectless space all around, as if your awareness is exploring the quiet background.
3. **Rest in alert, wordless awareness:** Let your awareness relax into that open silence. **Rest as the awareness** that is simply present and alert without words ¹⁴. For a few moments, just *be aware of being aware* – thoughts might still arise, but notice how you are observing them from a quieter, wordless space.

(This glimpse gives a direct taste of **“quiet mind”** not by force, but by shifting into the already quiet context of awareness. It’s like discovering the calm silence that is ever-present behind the noise.)

• **Glimpse 2: “Observer from the Room”** – *This exercise shifts the location of your awareness, giving a new perspective on the mind:*

1. **Locate your current sense of self:** First, notice **where your attention is located** right now. Most of us feel like our mind or “awareness center” is in our head (behind the eyes) ⁹. Acknowledge that feeling of sitting *inside* your head looking out.
2. **Move awareness out, then look back:** Next, let your awareness **move outside your head** – as an experiment, *imagine your awareness drifting a few feet behind or above you*, or even to a far **corner of the room**. Then, from that new vantage point, **“look back” through awareness** at the “you” who sent it ⁹. In Loch’s instructions: *notice your attention in your head, then let awareness move to the corner of the room and look back through the eyes of awareness to the one who sent it* ⁸.
3. **Remain in spacious awareness:** Allow yourself to **rest in this shifted perspective** for a little while. Feel what it’s like for awareness to be all around, looking at the world (and your own body-mind) from the outside. You might sense that your true **identity is this open awareness** that pervades the space, rather than the tiny thinker behind your eyes. Thoughts and feelings can still arise, but now they are just events happening *within* a larger space of consciousness. Notice the relief, ease, or natural calm that comes from this spacious awareness.

(This glimpse helps you experience what Kelly calls **“open-hearted awareness”** – a mind that is not stuck inside the head. Many people report a immediate sense of freedom and peace when doing this, as if a weight drops off.)

Tips for practicing: You can do these glimpse exercises with eyes closed or open, whichever makes it easier to *feel* the shift. Loch Kelly often recommends practicing with **eyes open during daily activities**, so that awake awareness becomes integrated with normal life (not just something you find in solitude). For example, you might pause occasionally while at work, walking, or even eating, and take a 30-second glimpse break – tuning into the space around you, or the awareness that’s already effortlessly aware. Each

time you do a glimpse, you are essentially “**remembering**” **your true nature** and training your brain to return to that peace and clarity more readily.

Finally, remember that the effect of **Effortless Mindfulness** is cumulative. One glimpse can be powerful, but the real transformation comes from doing “*small glimpses, many times*” over days and weeks ¹². You might set an intention to have a few mindful pauses every day. Over time, these micro-meditations will familiarize you with awake awareness until it becomes normal to live from this space. The beauty of Loch Kelly’s approach is that awakening is approached *gradually, yet directly* – each glimpse is a direct taste of freedom, and by stringing those moments together through consistent practice, you truly learn to “live from awake awareness.” With patience and frequent practice, **effortless mindfulness** becomes genuinely effortless – an awakened way of being, available anytime.

Sources: Loch Kelly’s teachings on Effortless Mindfulness and awake awareness ¹⁵ ¹⁶ ¹⁰ ¹⁴ ⁴ (see linked references for details and examples). Enjoy exploring these practices, and as Loch often says, “*welcome home*” to the awareness that is already within you.

¹ What Is Awake Awareness | Sounds True

<https://www.soundstrue.com/a/resources/blog/what-is-awake-awareness/?srsltid=AfmBOoouGlccKDIUTOdAj684peCfP87pzOsYgjSvaFB8618NbeY1QnIV>

² ⁵ ⁶ ⁷ ¹⁵ Effortless Mindfulness: Awakening Glimpse by Glimpse - Tricycle: The Buddhist Review

<https://tricycle.org/dharmataalks/loch-kelly-effortless-mindfulness/>

³ ¹⁰ ¹¹ ¹² ¹³ ¹⁴ What Is a Mindful Glimpse? | Loch Kelly

<https://lochkelly.org/what-is-a-mindful-glimpse>

⁴ Mindful Glimpses | Loch Kelly

<https://lochkelly.org/mindful-glimpses>

⁸ ⁹ ¹⁶ The Way of Effortless Mindfulness with Awakin Calls | Podcast | Loch Kelly

<https://lochkelly.org/the-way-of-effortless-mindfulness-with-awakin-calls-podcast>